Overview: Overlearning and Repetition

Overlearning means continuing to practise a skill after the pupil has demonstrated initial mastery. This isn't about boring repetition—it's about embedding knowledge so deeply that recall becomes automatic. When information is truly overlearned, it frees up working memory for higher-level thinking. For pupils who struggle to retain information, who seem to "lose" skills between lessons, or whose EHCP mentions difficulties with consolidation, overlearning provides the repeated exposure their brains need to move learning from fragile short-term memory into robust long-term storage.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil masters skill in lesson but forgets by next session
- Says "We've never done this before" when you have
- Needs to relearn basics at the start of each unit
- Can't apply previously taught skills to new contexts

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Identify skills that need overlearning

Which skills does this pupil repeatedly forget? Which basics do they need automatic so they can focus on higher-level thinking?

Tip: Prioritise foundational skills: number bonds, phonics patterns, key vocabulary, procedures.

2 Build in immediate repetition

When the pupil gets something right, don't move on immediately. Have them do 3-5 more successful repetitions in that session.

Teacher says: "Great, you've got it. Let's do a few more to lock it in."

Tip: These extra repetitions should feel like success, not punishment.

3 Schedule spaced review

Plan when you'll revisit this skill. Use expanding intervals: next day, then 3 days, then a week, then a fortnight.

Teacher says: "We'll come back to this tomorrow, and again next week. That's how we make it stick."

Tip: Put review moments in your planner—don't rely on memory.

4 Use active retrieval

Don't just show the information again—ask the pupil to retrieve it. Testing strengthens memory more than restudying.

Teacher says: "Before I show you, can you remember what we did last time?"

Tip: If they can't retrieve it, prompt minimally before showing the answer.

5 Vary the format

Same skill, different presentation. Flashcards one day, verbal quiz the next, written practice another day. Variation maintains engagement.

Tip: Small changes prevent boredom while reinforcing the same underlying skill.

6 Make it routine

Build daily review into your lesson structure. Predictable review routines reduce planning load and ensure consistency.

Teacher says: "Every lesson starts with our five quick questions on what we've learned before."

English Example: Spelling patterns (homophones)

Year 7 pupil confuses their/there/they're in every piece of writing despite being taught multiple times.

> **Session 1: Teach with memorable distinctions**
>
> **Teacher:** Teach each word with a memorable hook: "their = heir (ownership)", "there = here (place)", "they're = they are (contraction test)".
>
> **Pupil:** Learns the distinctions. Practises 10 sentences choosing the correct form.

> **Session 1: Overlearning**
>
> **Teacher:** After pupil gets 3 right, continue with 5 more. Say: "You've got it—let's make it stick."
>
> **Pupil:** Completes additional practice. Confidence builds with repeated success.

> **Daily: Quick quiz in starter**
>
> **Teacher:** Include 2 their/there/they're sentences in every lesson starter for 3 weeks.
>
> **Pupil:** Retrieves correct form daily. Begins to automatise the decision process.

> **Varied contexts: Spot the error**
>
> **Teacher:** Show sentences with deliberate errors. "Find and fix: There going to the park."
>
> **Pupil:** Applies knowledge in different format. Identifies "They're" as correct.

> **Writing integration**
>
> **Teacher:** During writing, prompt: "You've used 'there'—which one is it? Ownership, place, or contraction?"
>
> **Pupil:** Self-checks using the memorable hooks. Transfers skill to authentic writing.

Maths Example: Times tables (6x table)

Year 5 pupil learns 6x table facts but forgets them within days. Needs automaticity for division and fractions work.

Day 1: Initial teaching with overlearning

Teacher: Teach 6x1 to 6x6 using visual arrays. Once pupil answers correctly, continue with 5 more practice rounds.

Pupil: Answers correctly multiple times. Brain strengthens pathways through repetition.

Day 1 end: Quick retrieval

Teacher: At lesson end, ask: "Quick fire—6x3? 6x5? 6x2?" Celebrate quick recall.

Pupil: Retrieves facts from memory. Experiences success.

Day 2: Spaced retrieval

Teacher: Start lesson with flashcard review of yesterday's facts. If stuck, show array briefly then ask again.

Pupil: Retrieves with some effort. Correct answers after prompts still strengthen memory.

Day 4: Varied practice

Teacher: Play "times table tennis"—verbal back-and-forth. Then written quiz. Mix in facts from 6x7-6x12.

Pupil: Practises in different formats. Starts combining with new facts.

Week 2 onwards: Maintenance

Teacher: Include 6x table in daily starter. 2-3 questions mixed with other content.

Pupil: Maintains automaticity through regular low-stakes retrieval.

Science Example: Safety symbols

Year 8 pupil cannot remember hazard symbols despite seeing them every practical. Needs this for safe working and exams.

Initial teaching with multiple exposures

Teacher: Teach 4 key symbols with actions: oxidising (flame gesture), corrosive (eating away motion), toxic (skull), flammable (fire).

Pupil: Associates each symbol with word and action. Repeats matching game 3 times.

Same lesson: Immediate retrieval

Teacher: Cover symbols. "Show me the action for corrosive. Now point to the corrosive symbol."

Pupil: Retrieves from memory using action as memory aid.

Every practical: Embedded review

Teacher: Before each practical: "What symbols are on today's chemicals? What do they mean? What precautions?"

Pupil: Identifies symbols in real context. Links to actual safety behaviour.

Weekly quiz: Spaced retrieval

Teacher: Include 2 symbol questions in weekly science quiz. Mix with other content.

Pupil: Retrieves symbols alongside other knowledge. Spacing strengthens retention.

Month 2: Add symbols

Teacher: Introduce 2 more symbols. Review all 6 with the action game.

Pupil: Builds on secure foundation. Original 4 now automatic; brain has capacity for new ones.